

Who remains out of reach for European institutions? Individual determinants and spatial patterns of citizen impermeability to EU digital communication

1. Research Questions and Motivation

The institutions of the European Union (EU) are investing increasing resources in digital communication and social media presence with the explicit objective of bringing the European project closer to its citizens and narrowing the long-diagnosed “communication deficit” between Brussels and the national public spheres (De Wilde et al., 2014; Hänska & Bauchowitz, 2019). However, a significant number of European citizens not only refrain from following EU institutions on social media, but also state that no change in communication strategy would induce them to do so (European Parliament, 2026). This last group (citizens who are, in effect, communicatively “unreachable”) constitutes an analytical puzzle that cuts across the literatures on institutional trust, political disaffection and the digital divide.

Against this backdrop, the present study is structured around two interrelated research questions:

- **RQ1.** *Which individual-level characteristics predict that a European citizen will be completely impermeable to any change in the digital communication strategy of EU institutions?*

More specifically, this research aims to explain to what extent do socio-demographic variables (age, gender, education, income, occupational status, place of residence) and behavioural variables (institutional trust, levels of Euroscepticism, political interest, patterns of media consumption) contribute to said digital impermeability. Prior research on the digital divide in the EU has identified systematic socio-demographic gradients in online behavior (Cruz-Jesus et al., 2016; Gomes & Dias, 2015), while the literature on political disengagement has stressed the role of low institutional trust and political apathy in driving withdrawal from democratic processes (Hobolt & De Vries, 2016). These two strands may be converging in the specific case of EU digital communication, producing a distinctive profile of the “unreachable” citizen.

- **RQ2.** *Is there systematic geographical heterogeneity in this phenomenon across the European landscape?*

The emerging literature on the “geography of EU discontent” (Dijkstra et al., 2020) has documented that Euroscepticism and political disaffection are not randomly distributed across the European territory, but concentrate in regions experiencing long-term economic stagnation, demographic decline or so-called “development traps”. If impermeability to EU digital communication shares roots with these broader disaffection syndromes, one would expect it to display analogous spatial patterns. In turn, testing this

hypothesis requires moving beyond purely individual-level analysis and incorporating a multilevel or geographically explicit approach.

2. Data

The data for this project comes from the Social Media Survey 2025 (Flash Eurobarometer n° 3592), produced by Ipsos for the DG Communication Public Opinion Unit of the European Parliament. The survey was conducted in June 2025 (11.06.2025–18.06.2025) and covers all 27 EU member states. Relevant information:

- Total sample: 26,114 respondents.
- Study subsample (respondents not currently following any EU institution on social media, Q8 ≠ 6): approximately 22,167 observations.
- Analyses will use the country-level outcome weight (w1).

The survey collects detailed information on media behavior, EU attitudes, institutional trust, exposure to disinformation, and sociodemographic characteristics, allowing for a rich empirical specification.

3. Variables

Dependent variable: Q11_9, a binary indicator equal to 1 if the respondent selected the option “Nothing would make me follow these accounts” in question Q11 (What would make you more likely to follow EU institution accounts on social media?), and 0 otherwise. This variable captures absolute impermeability to any communicative intervention and is the most frequently selected item in Q11 (27.1% of the subsample).

Independent variables will expectedly be organized into four theoretically motivated blocks:

- **EU attitudes:** Q20 (importance of EU membership), Q21 (general position towards the EU), Q23 (follow-up of European politics);
- **Media behavior and social media use:** Q3_1 and Q3_2 (frequency of media use), Q4a (information sources), Q5 (platforms used), Q7 (forms of engagement with political content);
- **Barriers to following:** Q10_3 (distrust), Q10_5 (content perceived as irrelevant), Q10_7 (content perceived as too technical);
- **Sociodemographic characteristics:** D1 (age), D2 (sex), D4 (education level), D12 (country of residence).

4. Methodological Strategy

The analysis is structured in two complementary blocks:

- **Block 1 - Binary logistic regression:** a binary logistic regression model will be estimated with Q11_9 as the dependent variable. The specification will include the four predictor blocks described above, introduced sequentially to assess each

block's incremental contribution. Effects will be interpreted using predicted probabilities and average marginal effects (AMEs). Standard errors will be clustered at the country level to account for the sampling structure.

- **Block 2 - Spatial analysis:** country-level impermeability rates (proportion of Q11_9 = 1) will be aggregated by member state and mapped using choropleth maps with EU country polygons. Global Moran's I will be computed to assess whether significant spatial autocorrelation exists. If autocorrelation is significant, a spatial regression model (spatial lag or spatial error) will be estimated at the aggregate level using country-level attitudinal and macroeconomic predictors.

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